



When Things Go Wrong in Transit

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 14 of 18 · Running the Load · about a 15-minute read

It's not *if*, it's *when*. Marcus is rolling to Dallas, dead on schedule — and then the truck dies on the shoulder of I-20, two hundred miles out, three hours before his appointment. Or the route ahead floods. Or he's been parked at a shipper for five hours and his clock is almost gone. In that moment, exactly one thing decides how it goes: do you have a method, or do you panic?

The dispatcher who freezes — who hides the problem and hopes, or fires off ten frantic calls in no order — turns a bad break into a catastrophe. The dispatcher with a method stays calm, works the problem in the right order, and keeps the load alive.

Brokers remember exactly who kept their head when it counted. Trouble in this business is guaranteed — so getting good at handling it isn't a nice-to-have. It's one of the most valuable skills you will ever build.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Run a method on *any* in-transit problem — a breakdown, a delay, weather, hours running out, a detention that's spiraling. You'll know how to assess it fast, get ahead of it with the broker honestly, work the fix, and document it so you're protected. The goal isn't to prevent every problem — you can't. It's to handle the ones that come so well that a setback never becomes a failure.

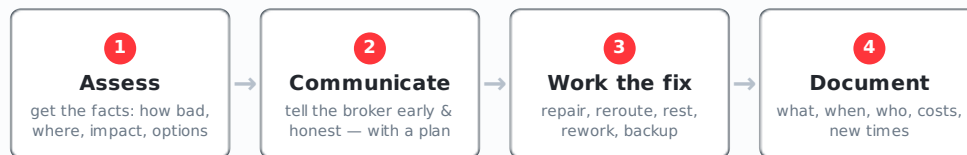
1 Trouble Is Normal; Method Beats Panic

Here's the mindset that separates the pros from everyone else: problems aren't failures. Every dispatcher who's ever run freight has hit breakdowns, delays, weather, hours problems, brutal detention. They come with the job. What actually gets judged — by the broker, by your carrier, by your own results — is *how you respond*.

And the two enemies of a good response are panic and avoidance: scrambling with no plan, or hiding the problem and praying it fixes itself. The cure for both is the same — a **repeatable method** you run every single time, so you're never improvising from zero in the worst moment. Learn the method once, and every problem after that becomes a procedure instead of a crisis. So let's build it.

2 The Method: Assess, Communicate, Fix, Document

For *any* in-transit problem, you run the same four steps, in this order:



Run it **in this order, every time** — a thirty-second pause to actually understand the situation beats a fast, wrong move. Learn it once and every problem becomes a procedure instead of a crisis.

- 1. Assess.** Get the facts before you react. What exactly happened? How bad is it? Where's the truck? What's the impact on the appointment and the load — and what are your options?
- 2. Communicate — early and honest.** The moment you understand it, tell the broker. Get ahead of it, and communicate the *right* way: the facts, plus a plan or an ETA, not just "we've got a problem." "*Marcus is broken down on I-20, I'm on the repair now, I'll have a firm new time within the hour*" is a professional update. Silence, or a vague panic call, is not. Keep the driver in the loop the same way. (*Handling a broker who's genuinely angry, or breaking hard news gracefully, is its own skill — a later lesson. Here the rule is simply: early, honest, with a plan.*)
- 3. Work the fix.** Now act on the options. Arrange the repair. Find the reroute. Get the driver legal rest. Rework the appointment. Pull in a backup truck or a transload if the freight has to keep moving. This is where you actually solve the problem instead of just reporting it.
- 4. Document.** Write down what happened and when, who you told, and what got agreed — the new times, any costs, the detention clock. It protects you when it's time to get paid, it settles disputes, and it's the difference between a claim you can prove and a loss you just eat.

3 The Common Problems, Same Loop Every Time

Each of these is just the four-step loop applied. Watch how the method holds:

- **The delay — late to the appointment**

Assess the realistic new ETA; tell the broker early so they can work their receiver; rework or reschedule the appointment if you can't make it; document. Caught early, a missed appointment is just a reschedule. Hidden until the no-show, it becomes a **service failure** — a black mark that follows your carrier.

- **The breakdown**

First, **is the driver safe?** Then assess severity and repair time; tell the broker with a plan; arrange the repair, or a backup truck or transload if it'll be down too long; rework the timing; document the costs.

- **Running out of hours**

Do the hours-vs-miles math from the feasibility lesson. If he can't make it legally, he **stops and rests** — you never tell a driver to run illegal hours to save an appointment. Rework the delivery around his reset and tell the broker. A late load is fixable; a logbook violation or a crash is not.

- **Detention that's spiraling**

He's stuck hours past his free time. **Document the arrival and wait times precisely**, keep the broker informed, push to get him released or turned, and make sure the detention actually gets claimed — that's owed money, but only if you tracked it.

● Reroute or diversion

Sometimes it's weather or a closure and you find an alternate route; sometimes the broker **diverts** the load to a different delivery point mid-transit — a **reconsignment**, which usually earns an accessorial. Either way: assess the alternate and the added miles and hours, reroute the driver, update the ETA and the broker, and document the change and any added cost.

Different problems, identical discipline: assess, communicate, fix, document. Once that's reflex, nothing on the road truly catches you flat.

4 Two Rules You Never Break

Two non-negotiables sit on top of the whole method, because breaking either one turns a problem into a disaster:

1 Never hide a problem or go silent.

The cover-up is always worse than the problem itself. Early honesty keeps the broker's trust even through bad news; going dark destroys it permanently, and they always find out anyway.

2 Never tell the driver to break the law.

Not over-hours, not unsafe through weather, not overweight. It's illegal, it's dangerous, and the liability lands squarely on the carrier. No appointment on earth is worth an accident or a violation.

Everything else in handling a problem is judgment. These two are not — they're the floor you stand on.

5 After the Problem: Document, Close the Loop, Learn

When the dust settles, three things finish the job. Make sure your **documentation is complete** — the timeline, the costs, the detention — because that's what you'll invoice and defend later. **Close the loop with the broker:** a short "delivered, here's where we landed" turns a rough load into proof that you're reliable when it matters. And **note what you'd do differently**, because today's problem is tomorrow's quick fix.

Here's the thing most new dispatchers don't believe until they see it: handling a problem *well* can leave a broker trusting you *more* than if it had gone smoothly. Anyone looks good on an easy load; you find out who a dispatcher really is when it goes sideways. The part of this that's purely about *how you talk* to an upset broker or a stressed driver under pressure is a craft of its own, with a whole lesson later. What you've got now is the thing that comes first: the operational response that keeps the load alive.

Walkthrough — Marcus Breaks Down 200 Miles Out

The method in action (anchor: Atlanta → Dallas, Thursday 1:00 PM appointment) — the alternate "things go wrong" branch of the run you watched in the last lesson.

RUN THE LOOP

The situation: Marcus calls — truck's down on I-20, ~200 mi out, ~3 hrs before the 1:00 PM. He's safe, off the road. The 1:00 is not happening.

1 ASSESS

Mechanical; not a roadside 10-min fix — looking at a shop, ~5+ hrs down. Appointment can't be made. Options: repair + reschedule, or (if down too long) a backup truck / transload.

2 COMMUNICATE

Call Smith **now**: "Marcus is broken down on I-20, ~200 out, mechanical, ~5 hrs. We won't make the 1 o'clock. I'm on the repair and reworking delivery; firm new ETA to you within the hour."

3 WORK THE FIX

Get him to a shop / roadside service; confirm he's safe and has what he needs; rework the delivery with Smith and the receiver for next available (next morning); decide repair-vs-backup as the ETA firms.

4 DOCUMENT Log the breakdown time, cause, every Smith call, the new appointment, and costs (repair, possible layover).

Delivers next morning — late, but clean, with Smith informed at every step and reassured. Contrast the "hide-and-hope": same breakdown, blown delivery, broker hears it from his customer, carrier looks incompetent.

Same breakdown, two completely different endings — and the only variable was the method. Marcus's truck dying wasn't the failure; it was just a fact to manage. Notice you didn't fix the truck with a phone — you assessed, you got ahead of it honestly, you worked the fix, and you wrote it all down. That's the entire job when things go wrong.

Module 14 Glossary — your quick reference

The problem-response terms — plus the mid-transit change you'll meet on the road.

When a load is in trouble

Service failure

A missed commitment that counts against your carrier — most often a blown appointment discovered too late to fix. Caught and communicated early, a delay is just a reschedule; hidden until the no-show, it becomes this.

Reconsignment / diversion

When the broker redirects a load to a different delivery point mid-transit. Usually earns an accessorial; you assess the added miles and hours, reroute, update the broker, and document the change.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. When a problem hits in transit, what are the four steps, in order?
2. Marcus breaks down three hours before delivery. After confirming he's safe, what's your next move?
3. Name a rule you must never break when a load is in trouble.
4. The driver will run out of hours before the appointment. What do you do?
5. Why document a problem thoroughly, and what does closing the loop with the broker do?

ANSWERS

1. Assess → Communicate (early & honest, with a plan) → Work the fix → Document.
2. Assess the situation (severity, repair time, impact, options), then communicate to the broker immediately and honestly with a plan/ETA — don't hide it. Then work the fix (repair/backup, rework the appointment) and document.
3. Never hide a problem or go silent on the broker; and never tell the driver to run illegal or unsafe (over-hours, weather, overweight). Either answer is correct.
4. He stops and rests legally — never push an illegal run; rework the delivery appointment around his reset and tell the broker early. A late load is recoverable; a violation or crash is not.
5. Documentation protects you for pay and detention claims and disputes (a claim you can prove vs. a loss you eat); closing the loop ("delivered, here's where we landed") builds trust and reputation.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 15: DELIVERY, POD & GETTING PAID

Whether it ran smooth or you had to fight it through a breakdown, the load finally rolls up to the receiver's dock. Now comes the finish line of every single load: getting unloaded cleanly, getting the paperwork that *proves* you delivered, and turning that proof into money in the bank. That's three things that decide whether all this work actually pays — and it's exactly where we go next.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches the in-transit response method as a generic skill. Your own operation adds its specifics — its escalation SOP (who to notify internally, and when a problem goes to a lead or after-hours); its breakdown/repair vendor network and roadside procedure; its backup-truck or transload procedure when freight must keep moving; its incident-log template (what to capture, where it lives); its detention-escalation thresholds and how detention gets claimed; and its after-incident reporting and review. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*